historian writes that defensive firing from the fort was so relentless ‘that in the dark nights . . . no man dared to raise his head, and a demon even would not move about’.[15]

But Abul Fazl was undaunted. He wrested command of the expedition and sent two contingents into the night, following close behind himself. Their scout lost his way, Asirgarh opened fire, but still, in ‘the heat of the battle, and the rain of cannonballs, at dawn I mounted the scaling ladder’. The writer had managed to breach one of Asirgarh’s three encircling walls. The enemy retreated. Soon afterwards, Bahadur sent an ambassador to Akbar, following meekly behind, and surrendered.

Bahadur should not have lost. The fortress had ‘such abundance of stores, such numbers of guns, so many defenders’, writes Abul Fazl – its occupants should have been able to tire out any besieging force, even Akbar’s.

One of the emperor’s new mansabdars, Jani Beg, the former ruler of Sindh who had lost his kingdom to Akbar’s army some years previously, was now a lonely drinker in Akbar’s court. Jani Beg had surveyed the towering black walls of Asirgarh with some feeling, it seems, and declared that ‘if Asir had been his, he would have held it for a hundred years’.[16]

Asirgarh’s generals seemed to feel the same. Their king, Bahadur, might have gone to Akbar’s camp, but they would not surrender the fort until they got a letter from him telling them to do so. The siege continued.

Eventually, after ‘pressure was put on him’,[17] Bahadur agreed to write a letter of surrender to his generals – one Abyssinian and several Portuguese. His command was not well received. According to a Jesuit Father’s report of the event, Asirgarh’s Abyssinian general gave a rousing speech against the surrender, then strangled himself.[18] Despite its fallen king, Asirgarh might have remained firm against the Mughal troops.

But what was rock, what were guns, what was abundant grain or endless resolve in the face of Akbar’s blessed luck? The fortress was struck by a plague.

Jani Beg of Sindh, watching sullenly from the sidelines, may have shaken his head in disbelief. It was a plague, too, that had brought about his defeat – another of Akbar’s miracles by which only the besieged Sindhis succumbed to a great sickness, not the Mughals. Akbar wasn’t surprised when he heard the news. ‘The True Artist [God] made an old woman the